India (and what we now call South Asia) that has never experienced total war.

This is not to wish total war on India. It is to suggest that the country has yet to develop the soft, hard, and social infrastructure for the determined, responsible pursuit of power which it will need if it wants to catch up with China. Soft infrastructure consists of ideas, data, bureaucracies, rules, laws, and other politico-administrative structures that allow for the mobilization of tens of millions of people and their coordination towards collective goals. Hard infrastructure consists of all the material elements of power – mass education facilities (school and universities), affordable health care, skilled and healthy populations, energy and transport, agricultural and industrial capabilities, communication and computing systems, science and technology, and military capabilities.

Soft and hard infrastructure are not enough. A country that wants to attain power globally must also have social infrastructure: a mass population that has been emancipated from feudal servitude and debilitating forms of stratification (for example, class, caste). That in turn means radical political reform and, in all probability, a society that has changed from predominantly or substantially rural to largely urban. It is impossible to build a modern Great Power on deep, enduring inequalities and a huge rural population. Just reading through this list of necessary social infrastructure should give the reader a sense of the challenges that will have to be faced to reduce the power gap with China. All this must be accomplished, it bears saying, at the same time as India and the rest of the world enter a period of extraordinary planetary change that will set limits on what can be done and how quickly (to put it mildly): China made its power moves before the onset of climate change; India will have to do so in the middle of the biggest crisis that modern humans have faced.

The road ahead for India is not an impossible one. But it would be fanciful to think that matching China is just a matter of attaining double-digit rates of growth, doubling GDP every decade, producing indigenous weapon systems, and external balancing by aligning with Great Powers. Far more fundamental change will be needed, almost a civilizational change.